

PPE 101: Morality, Markets, and Government

University of San Diego | Fall 2026 | TTH 2:30-3:50 | Finestone

Professor Information

Email Address: kfinestone@san Diego.edu

Office Location: Founders Hall 166 C

Course Information

Course Time: 2:30 PM-3:50PM

Course Days: Tuesday & Thursday

Course Location: Saints Hall 318

Course Description: This is a gateway course introducing you to an *integrated perspective* for understanding and guiding social processes as well as an opportunity to understand your place as an individual situated within a broader socio-political world. Many of the most pressing social questions require understanding how economics impinges on the political and how both require philosophical vindications for various institutions ranging from property rights to the nation-state. All of these exist within a historical context and by uncovering the ways in which these institutions relate to one another, we will develop the tools to discern how best to make change in the world.

Core Requirements:

This course fulfills the Core Curriculum requirement for Ethical Inquiry and Critical Thinking.

This course does NOT fulfill the Core Curriculum requirement for Philosophical Inquiry.

Office Hours:

Monday: 1:30 PM – 3:30 PM

Wednesday: 12:30 PM – 3:30 PM

Final Exam:

December 17th, 2026

11:00 AM – 1:00 PM

Texts:

All texts will be made available via Canvas. The schedule below is subject to change. In the event of changes, I will send a class-wide email and announcement on Canvas.

Learning Outcomes for PPE101:

By the end of the course, students should be able to:

1. Explain and critically analyze several major theories of freedom, equality, and distributive justice. (FETI LO1)
2. Explain and critically analyze the economic function of property rights, the division of labor, and the market price system.
3. Develop an ethical analysis of key issues in economic and public policy (e.g. minimum wage laws, environmental regulation). (FETI LO2)
4. Reflect critically on one's own moral obligations as a global citizen, with special attention to how one's perspective and values are shaped by one's location in the social world. (FETI LO3, 5)
5. Critically evaluate others' arguments on key issues of public policy, and develop your own well-reasoned position in a way that integrates the moral, economic, and political knowledge you have gained in this course. (FETI LO4)

Learning Outcomes for Ethical Inquiry:

Students will demonstrate:

1. *Foundational Knowledge*: Describe and analyze key ethical concepts (e.g., justice, happiness, the good, moral value, virtue, dignity, rights, equality, etc.)
2. *Ethical Reasoning*: Reason ethically by drawing on major ethical theories and traditions (e.g., virtue ethics, feminist ethics, Catholic social thought, deontological ethics, consequentialist theories, etc.) or the values grounding those traditions (e.g., autonomy, utility, etc.) to normatively assess individual, professional, and institutional decisions
3. *Perspectival Reflection*: Analyze a contemporary ethical issue from multiple perspectives, including identifying potential biases on the basis of social location (e.g., historical, cultural, gender, racial, economic, religious, ability, etc.)
4. *Clarity of Argument*: Develop, articulate, and defend a well-reasoned judgment on a particular ethical issue, demonstrating nuance and ambiguity, as well as clarity and precision, in their thinking and writing about moral problems, concepts, and ideals.
5. *Ethical Self-Reflection*: Reflect on and evaluate their own ethical decisions, actions, and practices, as well as on their obligations as morally responsible agents.

Learning Outcomes for Critical Thinking:

Students will demonstrate:

1. Develop and support a credible thesis/hypothesis and conclusion using techniques of analysis in a manner appropriate to the relevant discipline(s) of the course.

Course Assessment:

Reading Quizzes – Throughout the semester, there will be comprehension quizzes covering assigned readings. The purpose of these quizzes is to test your completion and understanding of the reading assignment and to encourage class attendance.;

- Quizzes are **multiple choice**.
- Quizzes are given at the **beginning** of class. There is **no extra time**.
- Quizzes **cannot be redone**. Missing class will result in an “incomplete” quiz.
- Worst **single** grade (including “incompletes”) will be **dropped**.
- Quizzes are **difficult**, it is in your interest to closely read and work through relevant arguments. You are encouraged to come to **office hours** for clarification.

Game Scenarios – Throughout the semester there will be **3** game scenarios enacting many of the concepts, dilemmas, and solutions discussed in class. Each of these will require **both** an interactive element in class and an out-of-class reflective essay component.

- Game scenarios are **interactive**, meaning that attendance is required.
- Game scenarios **cannot be redone** out of class. Missing class will result in an “incomplete” grade. See **class schedule** for relevant dates and if missing class is genuinely unavoidable, an alternative assignment can be completed at instructor's discretion.

Participation – Philosophy is best learned through active conversation with others. It is therefore important that you be a regular participant in classroom discussions. Showing up to class regularly is a necessary, but not sufficient, condition for a good participation grade. To earn full credit for participation you need to be part of the conversation – share your opinion, ask a question, respond to someone else’s question. Active engagement is an essential part of the learning process.

Exams – There are **two** exams – one during the regular semester and one final exam. Each exam will consist of multiple-choice questions, short-answer questions, and possibly a longer essay. The final exam will be cumulative but will emphasize material covered in the final third of the course. **All exams – including the final - must be taken at the date and time at which they are scheduled on this syllabus.** No exceptions will be made except for cases of documented medical emergencies. Please look at the **class schedule** and check for conflicts.

Grade Composition:

Reading Quizzes:	15%
Game Scenarios	20%
Participation	10%
Midterm Exam:	20%
Final Exam:	35%

Grading Scale

A: 93% and up; A-: 90-92%; B+: 87-89%; B: 83-86%; B-: 80-82%; C+: 77-79%; C: 73-76%; C-: 70-72%; D+: 67-69%; D: 63-66%; D-: 60-62%; F: 59.9 or Below.

Technology Policy

All students are expected to **abstain** from using electronic devices while in class. These include smart phones, laptops, and other electronic notetaking devices connected to the internet. This policy is intended to create a distraction-free environment where genuine discussion is possible. For those in *need* of exceptions from this policy, it can be made on a case-by-case basis. Please see instructor if you have questions or concerns.

Artificial Intelligence Policy

All students are expected to **refrain** from using large language models (LLM's) for text generation for any and all written assignments. For this course, the only written assignments where this would be possible are *personal reflection* papers, if the reflection is not written by you then that is **cheating**. LLM's are allowed for study purposes and for copy-editing but it is the student who is ultimately responsible for the submission, not the LLM.

Academic Integrity

All students are expected to know and follow University Policies on cheating and plagiarism. See the Code of Academic Integrity. Outside research is *a good thing* in philosophy. Just cite it! If it is determined that you have cheated, you will fail the course and I may recommend that you be expelled from the University.

Academic Freedom

Academic freedom in a university differs from freedom of speech in the wider society; it is not the right to say just anything. It guarantees scholars – including both faculty and students – protection for their scholarly inquiry regardless of the conclusions that it reaches, while demanding respect for scholarly methods.

Class Schedule*

Date	Topic	Lecture	Reading	Assignment
9/3	Introduction	What is PPE?	None	None
9/8	Models and Rationality	Models at Work	None	None
9/10	Models and Rationality	Rationality as Principle	Popper (1967)	None
9/15	Models and Rationality	Man and Model	None	None
9/17	Models and Rationality	Interest, Altruism, and Specialization	Smith (1776)	None

9/22	Property and Trade	Ownership and Rights	Schmidtz (2008)	None
9/24	Property and Trade	An Evolving Institution	Guala (2001)	None
9/29	Property and Trade	Trust and Compliance	None	None
10/1	Property and Trade	Deception and Knowledge	None	Deception Game
10/6	Growth and Welfare	Growth and its Determinants	Lucas (1988)	None
10/8	Growth and Welfare	Measuring Wealth or Welfare	Albrecht (2025)	None
10/13	Growth and Welfare	Efficiency and Minimal Fairness	None	None
10/15	Midterm Exam	None	None	Exam
10/20	Prices and Control	Value and Prices	None	None
10/22	No Class	None	None	None
10/27	Prices and Control	The Socialist Calculation Debate	Hayek (1945)	None
10/29	Prices and Control	Price Gouging	Zwolinski (2008)	None
11/3	Prices and Control	Extortion and Community	None	Extortion Game
11/5	Legitimacy and Democracy	Rational Voting	Downs (1957)	None
11/10	Legitimacy and Democracy	Tyranny and Voting Rules	Riker (1992)	Legitimacy and Democracy
11/12	No Class	None	None	None
11/17	Legitimacy and Democracy	Consensus and Choice	None	Voting Game
11/19	Legitimacy and Democracy	Central Bank Independence	Fischer (1995)	None
11/24	Rules and Discretion	Tinkering or Ordering	Popper (1944)	None
12/1	Rules and Discretion	Expectations and Policymaking	McCallum (1979)	None
12/3	Rules and Discretion	Statecraft and the Private Sphere	Lerner (1972)	None
12/8	Conclusion	Disciplining Interdisciplinarity	None	None
12/10	Review	Review	None	None
12/17	Final Exam	None	None	Final Exam

* Class Schedule is subject to change. All changes will be reflected on Canvas. Please contact the instructor if you have questions or concerns.